



Birla Institute of Technology & Science, Pilani
Pilani | Dubai | Goa | Hyderabad

ACADEMIC— UNDER GRADUATE STUDIES DIVISION

Second Semester 2025-26 Course Handout Part II

Date: 05 January 2026

In addition to part I (General Handout for all courses appended to the Timetable), this portion gives further specific details regarding the course.

Course Number: HSS F316

Course Title: Popular Literature and Culture of South Asia

Instructor-in-charge: Dr. Shriya Raina

1. **Course description:** South Asia as a region; culture and its representation through literature and cinema; politics of representation, breaking the stereotypes; bringing in the marginalized voices; writings of women; identity formation; concept of majority and minority; commonality in spite of all the differences, violence, migration and dislocation.
2. **Scope and Objective:** The objective of the course is to introduce students to Literature and Popular Culture of South Asia. In doing so, it will familiarize students to perspectives and scenarios that differ from their own culture, thereby, helping them to have deeper understanding of other cultures. This course aims to bridge the gaps in our understanding of our neighbors and enable us to have broader perspectives.
3. **Course Learning Outcomes:** After completing the course, the students would be able to:
 - Have basic concepts of South Asia as a region
 - Understand, analyze different productions from the region and ponder on the implications of such representations
 - Apply acquired knowledge in real life scenarios by acknowledging common history, heritage and culture, as well as, the diversity of the region
2. **Text Book: We will pick and choose from the following texts:**

T-1 Katha Series: 20 Stories from South Asia. New Delhi, 2012.

1. *Bitter Fruit: The Very Best of Saadat Hasan Manto*: Edited and Translated by Khalid Hasan

2. Kunzang Choden's *The Circle of Karma*– A Novel
3. Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger*
4. Khaled Hosseini's *The Kite Runners*
5. Shyam Selvadurai's *Funny Boy*
6. Taslima Nasrin's *Lajja* (*The Shame*)

Films: We will pick and choose from the following films:

1. The Kite Runner (2007)
2. Osama (2003)
3. Slumdog Millionaire (2008)
4. Namesake (2006)
5. The Reluctant Fundamentalist (2013)

Following class discussions and student input, alternative texts and movies will be added and announced in class. Relevant reference books and reading material will be circulated through Nalanda.

4. Course Plan:

Lecture No.	Learning Objectives	Topics to be covered	Reference to Chap/Sec/Book	Learning Outcome
1-3	Introduction to South Asia	Introduction to South Asian society and culture	Reading Material	Understanding the geographical location and culture of South Asia; identifying the common traits, cultural nuances and literary productions of the region.
5-6	Characteristic Features of South Asian Culture, Society and Literature	An Overview of Contemporary Literature	Reading Material	
7-12	Afghanistan	Understanding Afghanistan through pop lit and films	<i>The Kite Runners</i> : both text and film; Osama (2003) Alternative readings (TBA)	Understanding the country by analyzing the prescribed text and movies; learning about the history and culture through popular literature and films.

13-19	Pakistan	Understanding Pakistan through pop literature and film	T-1 or Saadat Hasan Manto and <i>The Reluctant Fundamentalist</i> (2013); Alternative readings (TBA)	Locating Pakistan within the South Asian region and understanding its implications.
20-25	Bangladesh/Nepal	Understanding Bangladesh and Nepal through pop literature and films	T1 and documentaries/movies/ Taslima Nasrin; Alternative readings (TBA)	Learning about Bangladesh and Nepal and their people and culture through these works; connecting them with the wider representation of the region.
26-29	Bhutan	Understanding Bhutan through pop literature and films	The Circle of Karma and documentaries/movies; Alternative Readings (TBA)	Understanding Bhutan as a South Asian country (through the prism of religion and gender), and its implications.
30-34	Srilanka	Understanding Srilanka through pop literature	T-1 or Funny Boy; Alternative Readings (TBA)	Understanding minority discourse in South Asia through the prescribed text on Srilanka.
35-40	India	Understanding India through pop literature and film	The White Tiger and/or Slumdog Millionaire (2008); Alternative readings (TBA)	Identifying politics of representation and overarching discourse based on widely circulated works; applying similar concepts to look at South Asia as a broader trope.
41-43	Comparative analysis of the texts already read and the movies already watched.	Comparative analysis	All discussed above.	Understanding South Asia as a region; identifying similarities, common heritage and culture, as well, the diversity it espouses.

5. Evaluation Scheme:

Component	Weightage	Duration	Date and time	Comments
Continuous Evaluations: three essays to be drafted in class; one assignment submission	40% (20% essays + 20% assignment)	45 min	TBA	Two essays will be included in the final evaluation. Assignment will be post mid-semester.
Mid Semester	20%	90 min	As per the AUGSD schedule	Open book
Comprehensive	40%	180 min	TBA	Open book

Plagiarism and any form of academic dishonesty will be heavily penalized. Students are strongly advised to stay up-to-date with classwork.

- 6. Attendance Policy:** Each student is expected to attend all classes and participate in all evaluation components.
- 7. Chamber consultation hours:** Wednesdays, 4 to 5 PM.
- 8. Makeup Policy:** Makeup will be given only for genuine cases.

Dr. Shriya Raina